

WARHAMMER 40,000 DAWN OF WAR DARK CRUSADE

A sound multiplayer experience... but that's about it

Dark Crusade is the third instalment in the *Dawn Of War 40000* series, following *Winter Assault*, which was released a year ago. The *DOW 40000* series is loved for its fast-paced, violent action, somewhat of a rarity in RTS games. Unlike the original game and its sequel—which had a definite single-player storyline—*Dark Crusade* doesn't have much of one. It's best described as a "conquer all maps, conquer world" RTS, with the introduction of turn-based elements.

You start out choosing one of seven factions, and will play one round at a time, defeating neighbours as you aim to conquer the planet of Kronus, which is somehow of great import to all the galaxy. *Dark Crusade* introduces the Necrons and the Tau as playable races, the other five having been brought in from earlier versions of the game. Also, each civilisation gets a unique unit, adding more depth to the gameplay. Each civilisation starts with a home base, and you can choose to attack adjacent territories per turn. Certain territories contain relics, which endow your forces with special abilities when you control them. Eliminating races from the running to control Kronus is what you need to do, albeit a step at a time.

The graphics remain unchanged from the earlier games, and are still pretty good for the genre. So, you might ask, what's different? Well, nothing much, to be honest—besides what we've already mentioned, and making all higher research tree advancement ridiculously cheaper.

You'll find teching up a snap, so you can concentrate on the one thing *DOW* achieves flawlessly—combat. The number of civilisations available also adds much-needed depth and variety to the game. Thankfully, THQ has added a lot of multiplayer maps to *Dark Crusade*, something that was sorely missed in *Winter Assault*.

Multiplayer aficionados will croon at the sheer number of options *Dark Crusade* offers. The lack of an involving single player campaign complete with twists and plots prevents us from rating this game higher.

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Rating: **6/10**
Developer: **Relic**
Publisher: **THQ**
Minimum System Requirements:
Pentium 4 1.6 GHz, 256 MB RAM,
64 MB DirectX 9 compliant card,
DirectX ready Sound Card

